Problem Interview Script - Codefi Farm Financial Planning

Interview Objectives & Setup

Objectives: - Validate that farmers experience acute visibility problem (not knowing farm P&L by field) - Understand decision-making process for input timing and pricing - Gauge willingness to consolidate messy farm data (time/effort cost) - Test if peer benchmarking builds trust before farmer-specific scenarios - Measure what constitutes "proof" that a tool saved money

Target Profile: Mid-scale commodity farmers (500-5,000 acres), corn/soybean focus, Midwest, active input decision-makers

Duration: 25-30 minutes

Recording: "Would you mind if I recorded this? Helps me take accurate notes."

Key instruction: Listen for *emotions* (frustration, anxiety, confidence gaps) not just feature requests.

Section 1: Opening & Context (4 min)

Goal: Build rapport, establish their role in input decisions

1. "Tell me about your farm operation. How many acres, what do you grow, and what's your role in day-to-day decisions?"
    - Follow-up: "Are you the primary person making input decisions, or do you work with someone?"
    - Listen for: Decision-making authority, complexity of farm structure
2. "How long have you been farming this operation?"
    - Follow-up: "What's changed most in your operation over the last 5 years?"
    - Listen for: Willingness to adopt new approaches, past changes they've made
3. "What's your relationship like with your lender, co-op, or agronomist?"
    - Listen for: Trust in advisors, dependency level, willingness to second-guess advice

Section 2: The Visibility Problem (7 min)

Goal: Uncover whether farmers lack real-time P&L visibility and feel acutely frustrated

1. "Walk me through how you track whether your farm is profitable. Where do you keep that information?"
   - Follow-up: "How current is that information? Do you know right now what your per-field profit was last year?"
   - Listen for: Fragmented data sources, incomplete records, time lag in understanding profitability
2. "When you're deciding whether to buy fertilizer now or wait, how do you know if that decision will be profitable?"
   - Follow-up: "Do you have a way to quickly model what different prices would mean for your bottom line?"
   - Listen for: Emotional language (stress, guessing, flying blind), lack of decision-support tools
3. "Tell me about a time you made an input timing decision and later realized it cost you money. What happened?"
   - Follow-up: "How did you find out it was a bad decision? How much did it cost?"
   - Listen for: Specific dollar impact, emotional weight of the mistake, whether they could have prevented it with better information

Section 3: Current Solutions & Workarounds (5 min)

Goal: Understand how they currently solve the visibility/decision problem

1. "How do you currently handle tracking input costs and yield by field? Walk me through your system."
   - Follow-up: "How much time does that take? Is it accurate?"
   - Listen for: Spreadsheets, paper notebooks, fragmented tools, manual data entry, frustration with process
2. "When you want to compare yourself to other farmers, how do you do that? Do you know how your costs compare to neighbors?"
   - Follow-up: "Would you want to know how you stack up against similar farms in your region?"
   - Listen for: Isolation from benchmarking data, curiosity about peer comparison, competitive

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awareness

3. "What would make it easier for you to understand your farm's profitability before making a big input decision?"
    - Follow-up: "How much time would you be willing to spend setting up a tool like that?"
    - Listen for: Willingness to change, appetite for automation, time constraints

Section 4: Data Consolidation Willingness (4 min)

Goal: Test whether farmers will consolidate messy data and how much friction they'll tolerate

1. "Imagine a tool that showed you your per-field P&L and let you run scenarios. But you'd need to upload your last 2-3 years of cost data first. How would you feel about that setup?"
    - Follow-up: "How complete is your cost data right now? Do you have itemized records, or rough estimates?"
    - Listen for: Anxiety about data entry, incomplete records, hesitation vs. enthusiasm
2. "If we could show you how your costs compare to farms like yours in Missouri, would that be valuable? What would you do with that information?"
    - Follow-up: "Would seeing peer benchmarks make you more confident in a tool, even if your own data was incomplete?"
    - Listen for: Interest in benchmarking, trust in peer comparison, whether benchmarks reduce anxiety about incomplete data
3. "If you saw a financial projection from a tool, what would make you confident enough to act on it or share it with your lender?"
    - Follow-up: "Would you trust it if it was based on incomplete data? What would you need to see?"
    - Listen for: Trust requirements, transparency expectations, liability concerns

Section 5: Willingness to Pay & ROI Measurement (4 min)

Goal: Gauge whether farmers would pay $150/month and how they measure tool ROI

1. "How much do you currently spend on tools to help with farm financial planning? (QuickBooks, DTN, co-op subscriptions, etc.)"
    - Follow-up: "Of that, how much is actually helping you make better input decisions?"

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    - Listen for: Current spending willingness, perceived ROI from existing tools

2. "If a tool helped you make one better input timing decision per year worth $5K-10K in avoided costs, what would you pay for that?"
    - Follow-up: "Would $150/month make sense for that kind of value?"
    - Listen for: Willingness-to-pay signals, how they quantify value, price sensitivity
3. "How would you know if a financial planning tool actually saved you money? What would the proof look like?"
    - Follow-up: "Would you want to see a dashboard showing 'scenarios you ran + decisions made + estimated impact'?"
    - Listen for: Need for tangible ROI communication, appetite for measurement tools, retention triggers

Section 6: Decision-Making Process & Influencers (3 min)

Goal: Understand who influences input decisions and how they validate recommendations

1. "When you're making a significant input decision, who do you talk to? How much weight does their opinion carry?"
    - Follow-up: "Would you feel more confident making that decision if you had your own financial analysis?"
    - Listen for: Advisor dependency, desire for independent analysis, relationship dynamics
2. "Do you ever push back on recommendations from your agronomist or co-op? What would cause you to do that?"
    - Follow-up: "If you had data showing a different approach was more profitable, would you use it?"
    - Listen for: Independence of thought, receptiveness to data-driven decisions, risk tolerance
3. "Is there anything else about how you make input decisions or track farm finances that we haven't discussed?"
    - Listen for: Unexpected pain points, secondary problems, insights you missed

Section 7: Closing & Referrals

Goal: Thank them and gather referrals

Thank you script: "This has been really helpful. You've given me a clear picture of how you manage farm finances and where the biggest frustrations are. We're building a tool specifically to address these issues, and your input has been incredibly valuable."

Referral request: "Do you know 2-3 other farmers in your area who face similar challenges with input timing decisions and farm profitability tracking? Would you be comfortable introducing us, or can I mention your name if I reach out?"

Close: "We'll be running a pilot soon. Would you be interested in testing an early version?"

Analysis Framework & Red Flags

After each interview, rate:

Problem Severity: 1-10 scale - Pain point frequency (daily/weekly/monthly) - Dollar impact of recent mistakes - Emotional intensity (frustration language)

Trust in Incomplete Data: 1-10 scale - Would they act on scenarios based on 60-80% complete data? - What transparency/assumptions do they need? - Would peer benchmarks increase trust?

Conversion Likelihood: Strong / Moderate / Weak - Would they consolidate farm data for a tool like this? - Willing to spend time on setup? - Price sensitivity ($150/month acceptable?)

Green Lights (Strong Validation): - Unprompted frustration about not knowing P&L - Specific recent decision that cost $X - Already spending money on similar tools - Asks detailed questions about how tool works - Willing to share with lender/agronomist as validation

Red Flags (Weak Fit): - Says gut instinct works fine for them - Doesn't know input costs off top of head (no awareness) - Resistant to consolidating data or learning new tool - Claims no bad input decisions in recent memory - Won't share results with advisor (low confidence)

Post-Interview Action Plan

Within 24 hours: 1. Write up 2-3 page interview notes (verbatim quotes critical) 2. Identify 3-5 key quotes about pain points, trust concerns, ROI measurement 3. Rate problem severity, trust willingness, conversion likelihood 4. Flag any surprising insights or secondary problems 5. Note specific dollar amounts farmers mentioned

After 5-7 interviews (minimum): 1. Look for patterns: Which pain points appeared in 80%+ of interviews? 2. Which red flags appeared most? How does this change product priorities? 3. Did peer benchmarking build trust? Or is farmer-specific data required? 4. What's the realistic data consolidation timeline? (2 weeks vs. 4 weeks) 5. Are farmers willing to pay $150/month? Are they anchoring lower? 6. Create findings summary for validation report and product roadmap update

Criteria for strong market fit: 80%+ of farmers validate the visibility problem as acute, 60%+ would consolidate data for a tool, 50%+ show conversion likelihood.